

# "I was put under house arrest"

*Taslima Nasreen spoke to ANSHUMAN BHOWMICK over telephone from her undisclosed Delhi shelter on the morning of November 28, a few hours before External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee made a statement on her in Parliament. Excerpts:*

**Q. Controversy never tires of you. What led to the latest phase?**

A. It started with the Hyderabad Press Club attack on August 9. It was just another book launch function, this time the Telugu translation of my writings. The only lacuna was the lack of police protection. The MLAs of a Muslim organisation attacked me purposefully. They believed an attack on me would make them popular among the uneducated Muslim populace.

**Q. You took a return flight to Kolkata the same evening. What happened afterwards?**

A. Once I returned from Hyderabad, the Kolkata Police began pressuring me to leave the city. They speculated about problems of various sorts—that a mob may march towards my residence, that the fundamentalists were ready to take my blood, that I may be killed, that police firing could lead to a riot, that I won't get a resident permit if I didn't leave the country. I was put under house arrest.

**Q. Are you sure about the implications of "house arrest"?**

A. To put the situation more simply, I was not allowed to leave my apartment at 7 Rawdon Street. I reported this to the governor. He advised me to inform the authorities in Delhi who had given me a visa. During those three months, I was allowed to move out only thrice. First, to visit my travel agent when I booked my tickets to Taipei. Second, when I left Kolkata to attend the Taipei poetry festival.

**Q. When was that?**

A. November 2 and 3. The police were keen to know my date of return. I

refused to oblige them as I had a suspicion they wouldn't let me return to Kolkata. Then on November 15, I was told to stay away from home as some Islamic organisations were scheduled to hold a march. At 5 a.m., I was escorted to a friend's place in Lansdowne (a south Kolkata locality). Once we reached there, the security blanket was removed. That scared me.

**Q. Is it true that Prasun Mukherjee, the then police commissioner of Kolkata, called on you?**

A. Yes, he came to my apartment in mid-August, a few days after the Barqatis issued a public fatwa on me in Kolkata. He told me that non-Bengali Islamic outfits had plans to kill me. So I should leave this place and return only

**Q. Did you notice any security lapse during the last few weeks?**

A. I was frightened when my escorts disappeared after I reached my friend's place on the 15th. The next day saw another agitation led by Siddikullah Chowdhury. There were agitations and road blocks close to my residence. They shouted, "Taslima, go back". Yet, only a few policemen could be seen around me. I panicked. I called up the special branch people.

**Q. What happened on the 21st?**

A. I followed the news channels on television throughout the day. In the evening, Bhutoria was sent to my residence. "Have you gone mad?" he said, "I have made every arrangement for you in Jaipur. Why don't you leave

**"Let the Centre take a decision so that I can live in Kolkata. I don't want to be harassed any more."**

when things were under control. I was asked to go to Europe or America, or to Thailand. I insisted on staying in Kolkata. He kept calling me. I kept refusing to buy his arguments. The last call came a few days after the Rizwanur Rahman controversy erupted. One day he said, the chief minister wanted me to leave for Kerala. All arrangements were made, the security cover was to remain intact and everything was to be confidential. I was not convinced. I told him, "Make it public. Tell the media. Or I'll tell the media myself." He got furious and disconnected the phone.

**Q. Did you breathe easy after Mukherjee was removed?**

A. Not at all. Vineet Goel, deputy commissioner (headquarters), began using the same words, the same tactics. For a change, he popped up the name Rajasthan from time to time. He found Sundeep Bhutoria, one of my acquaintances in Rajasthan who invited me once. Both Goel and Bhutoria kept saying the same thing. I refused to go.

Kolkata?" But I did not relent.

**Q. But you left the very next day.**

A. Yes. November 22 was a Thursday. From early in the morning, calls from Lalbazar started informing me that there would be an attack on me after the Namaaz on the Jumma day. I proposed leaving my Rawdon Street residence for areas like Salt Lake, Belgharia or Behala. But Goel insisted on leaving for Jaipur. He said, "Leave Kolkata for two-three days and return afterwards." I was so panicky that I couldn't say "no". The car came within minutes and I was handed over two flight tickets on my way to the airport. They were in different names.

**Q. What was the security arrangement like, in Jaipur?**

A. Hardly any security. Only a car came to pick me up. The driver dumped me at Shikha Hotel. The Rajasthan Police, it seemed, had no clue about my whereabouts. They were informed only after I took the flight. By then the media had surrounded the hotel. At about midnight, some policemen knocked on my hotel room door. I was told about the impending law and order problem and that I shouldn't stay there. I rang

**"I tried several times to call the chief minister. He avoided me but sent people asking me to leave the country."**